then, far more sophisticated and complex risk-assessment algorithms have been developed and have been handed more expansive purviews. By the early 2020s citizens in numerous countries routinely get prison sentences based in part on risk assessments made by algorithms that neither the judges nor the defendants comprehend.[31] And prison sentences are just the tip of the iceberg.

THE RIGHT TO AN EXPLANATION

Computers are making more and more decisions about us, both mundane and life-changing. In addition to prison sentences, algorithms increasingly have a hand in deciding whether to offer us a place at college, give us a job, provide us with welfare benefits or grant us a loan. They similarly help determine what kind of medical treatment we receive, what insurance premiums we pay, what news we hear and who would ask us on a date.[32]

As society entrusts more and more decisions to computers, it undermines the viability of democratic self-correcting mechanisms and of democratic transparency and accountability. How can elected officials regulate unfathomable algorithms? There is, consequently, a growing demand to enshrine a new human right: the right to an explanation. The European Union's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), which came into effect in 2018, says that if an algorithm makes a decision about a human – refusing to extend us credit, for example – that human is entitled to obtain an explanation of the decision and to challenge that decision in front of some human authority.[33] Ideally, that should keep in check algorithmic bias and allow democratic self-correcting mechanisms to identify and correct at least some of the computers' more grievous mistakes.

But can this right be fulfilled in practice? Mustafa Suleyman is a world expert on this subject. He is the co-founder of DeepMind, one of the world's most important AI enterprises, which is responsible for developing the AlphaGo program, among other achievements. AlphaGo was designed to play go, a strategy board game in which two players try to defeat each other by surrounding and capturing territory. Invented in ancient China, the game is far more complex than chess. Consequently, even after computers defeated human world chess champions, experts still believed that computers would never best humanity in go.